

ULTIMATE LAPTOP BUYING CHEAT-SHEET

Yetnesh Dubey | yetnesh@digit.in

The plan is simple. I will tell you exactly how to pick the best laptop based on different popular kind of workloads. And you will tell me how much it helped you out by emailing me a thank you note. I am kidding, the latter part is optional. You can if you want to though. Regardless, right now the market is filled with so many options that its honestly very confusing to know whether the laptop you're buying is a good deal for you or not.

Moreover, the additional number of available processors, GPUs, storage and RAM options can leave a buyer further perplexed. And thus can very well push them to make a bad purchase decision. So, keeping in mind the amount of time and the number of options in the market, here's a buying guide that's rich in all the details you need but is too long to read.

MAINSTREAM LAPTOPS

1 Main use cases

These laptops excel in low-medium level tasks like handling documents, spreadsheets, presentations, and other office apps. Modern processors enable light photo/video editing on platforms like



Canva and Filmora. Geared towards power efficiency rather than high performance, these laptops generally offer good battery life, often upwards of 6 hours, making them suitable for a variety of routine tasks.

2 Processors

Opt for Intel 11th to 13th Gen Core or AMD Ryzen 5000 or 7000 series processors. Intel excels in single-core performance and efficiency, especially 12th or 13th Gen with X86 Hybrid Architecture, while AMD offers better integrated graphics and robust multicore performance.

3 RAM

Choose from four RAM options: DDR4, LPDDR4, DDR5, and LPDDR5, with DDR5 and LPDDR5 being faster. LPDDR5 variants offer higher clock speeds but aren't user-upgradable, unlike DDR5 format RAM. The order of RAM speed is DDR4 < LPDDR4 < DDR5 < LPDDR5.

4 Storage

Opt for SSD storage over HDD for faster, more reliable performance. A minimum of 512GB storage is recommended, suitable for both work and personal use, regardless of the use case.

5 Display

Mainstream laptops typically have a 15.6-inch IPS LCD display, 250-300 nits brightness, and 178-degree viewing angle for clear visibility from multiple positions. Opt for IPS or OLED panels over TN for wider viewing angles and smoother visuals with higher refresh rates.

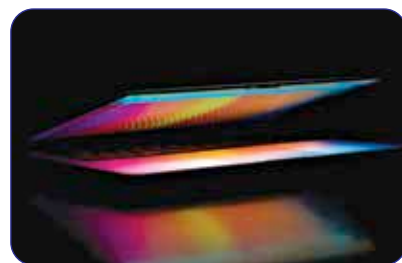
6 I/O ports

Ensure laptops have USB Type-A, Type-C ports, and a mix of I/O ports like HDMI, SD card reader for varied connectivity. Thunderbolt ports are a bonus for faster transfers. Opt for Ethernet ports for stable internet, and Wi-Fi 6, Bluetooth 5.0 for wireless connectivity.

7 Chassis, keyboard, build quality

Check for minimal chassis flex for a better typing experience. Key travel of around 1.0 to 2 mm is preferable; slim laptops have shorter key travel. Opt for metal construction or elements for durability and longevity.

THIN AND LIGHT LAPTOPS



1 Main use cases

Thin and Light laptops are ideal for individuals seeking a blend of portability and performance. They handle day-to-day tasks such as document editing, browsing, and media